

C801

Health Information Law and Regulations

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A patient treated in the ED of a hospital with a new helipad is transferred to a rehab facility across town. A nurse at the rehab facility calls for the ED notes. The hospital's legal counsel is on vacation. Does the hospital need the patient's written authorization to send the notes?

- A. No; disclosure for treatment is permitted without authorization.
- B. No, but only the minimum necessary may be sent.
- C. Yes; legal counsel must approve it first.
- D. Yes; written authorization is always required.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A billing clerk at a multi-specialty group with 60 physicians is submitting a claim for a knee MRI. The clerk asks for the patient's entire record, including 10 years of visits. What does HIPAA require?

- A. Release the full record, since payment is a permitted purpose.
- B. Refuse to release anything without authorization.
- C. Release it all, since minimum necessary applies only to treatment.
- D. Use only the information reasonably needed to support the MRI claim.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

For which disclosure does the minimum necessary standard NOT apply?

- A. To a health plan for payment.
- B. For an internal quality audit.
- C. None; it applies to every disclosure.
- D. To another provider for the patient's treatment.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A patient of a dermatology practice that recently changed its logo submits a written request for a copy of her records on March 1. The practice's release-of-information vendor is backlogged. Without an extension, by when must the practice generally act?

- A. Within 10 business days.
- B. Within 60 days.
- C. By March 31 (within 30 days).
- D. Whenever the vendor catches up.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A covered entity told a patient in writing about a delay and used its one allowed extension. What is the most total time it has to act on the access request?

- A. 60 days.
- B. 90 days.
- C. 30 days.
- D. No limit once an extension is used.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A home health agency with offices in two states discovers on June 10 that a stolen, unencrypted laptop held records for 700 residents of one state. The laptop was a 2021 model. Which notification duties apply?

- A. Notify HHS only.
- B. Notify the individuals, HHS, and prominent media in that state, all within 60 days of discovery.
- C. Notify the individuals; log it for HHS at year end.
- D. No notice is needed because the laptop was an older model.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A breach affected 120 individuals. When must the covered entity report it to HHS?

- A.** Within 60 days of discovery, along with media notice.
- B.** Never, because breaches under 500 are not reported to HHS.
- C.** Only if an individual files a complaint.
- D.** Within 60 days after the end of the calendar year in which it was discovered.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A federally assisted substance use disorder treatment program in a city with a new light-rail line receives a request from a patient's employer for treatment records. The patient has not consented. The program director has 20 years of experience. What should the program do?

- A.** Disclose if the experienced director approves.
- B.** Decline to disclose without the patient's written consent.
- C.** Disclose a summary without the diagnosis.
- D.** Disclose, because employers have a right to health records.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

An HIM department with a new scanning system receives a subpoena for a patient's records in a civil lawsuit, signed only by an attorney. There is no court order, no patient authorization, and no assurance that the patient was notified. What should HIM do?

- A.** Hold the records and work with legal to obtain assurances, authorization, or a court order.
- B.** Release it because the new scanner makes it easy.
- C.** Release the full record, since any subpoena forces release.
- D.** Throw the subpoena away.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

HIM receives an order for records signed by a judge. How does this differ from an attorney-signed subpoena?

- A.** It still requires patient authorization.
- B.** HIM may release the information the order names without patient authorization.
- C.** It is handled exactly like an attorney subpoena.
- D.** It allows release of the entire record no matter what it names.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A patient at an orthopedic clinic with Saturday hours notices that her chart lists the wrong allergy, and the physician agrees it is an error. The patient is a retired teacher. How should the record be corrected?

- A.** Refuse, since signed records may never be changed.
- B.** Delete the wrong entry so no one sees it.
- C.** Add a dated, signed amendment that corrects it while keeping the original entry visible.
- D.** Overwrite the field with the correct allergy, leaving no trace.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

An HIM coder at a pediatric hospital known for its research program finds documentation strongly suggesting child abuse that no one appears to have reported. The coder's supervisor says it is not the coder's job. What action is most consistent with legal and ethical duties?

- A.** Contact the parents directly to ask what happened.
- B.** Code the record and move on, as the supervisor said.
- C.** Escalate through the hospital's compliance or designated reporting channel so the required report is made.
- D.** Do nothing, since HIPAA bars any disclosure without authorization.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

A patient treated in the ED of a hospital ~~with a new helipad~~ is transferred to a rehab facility across town. A nurse at the rehab facility calls for the ED notes. ~~The hospital's legal counsel is on vacation.~~ Does the hospital need the patient's written authorization to send the notes?

Target word: authorization needed? **Decides:** Disclosure to another provider for treatment.

A	Correct	Treatment is part of TPO.
B	Confusion set	Minimum necessary does not apply to disclosures to a provider for treatment.
C	Camouflage	Counsel's absence does not change what HIPAA permits.
D	Absolute language	TPO disclosures are a standing exception.

2. Answer D Concept 2

A billing clerk at a multi-specialty group ~~with 60 physicians~~ is submitting a claim for a knee MRI. The clerk asks for the patient's entire record, including 10 years of visits. What does HIPAA require?

Target word: what may be used **Decides:** Payment use is subject to minimum necessary.

A	Dropped element	Permitted purpose still has the minimum-necessary limit.
B	Absolute language	Payment disclosures do not need authorization.
C	Inverted operation	Reversed: treatment is the exception, not the only case.
D	Correct	Payment uses are limited to the minimum necessary.

3. Answer D Concept 2 · transfer

For which disclosure does the minimum necessary standard NOT apply?

Target word: reverse: find the exception **Decides:** Disclosure to a provider for treatment.

A	Confusion set	Minimum necessary applies to payment.
B	Adjacent category	Operations are subject to minimum necessary.
C	Absolute language	There are exceptions, including treatment.
D	Correct	Treatment disclosures are exempt.

4. Answer C Concept 3

A patient of a dermatology practice ~~that recently changed its logo~~ submits a written request for a copy of her records on March 1. ~~The practice's release of information vendor is backlogged.~~ Without an extension, by when must the practice generally act?

Target word: deadline **Decides:** 30 days from the request.

A	Adjacent category	Not the federal HIPAA standard.
B	Confusion set	Mixes up the breach notification deadline.
C	Correct	HIPAA requires action within 30 days.
D	Camouflage	Vendor delays do not extend the legal deadline.

5. Answer A Concept 3 · transfer

A covered entity told a patient in writing about a delay and used its one allowed extension. What is the most total time it has to act on the access request?

Target word: total time with extension **Decides:** 30 days + one 30-day extension.

A	Correct	30 + 30 = 60 days.
B	Confusion set	Assumes two extensions; only one is allowed.
C	Dropped element	Leaves out the extension.
D	Absolute language	The extension is capped at 30 days.

6. Answer B Concept 4

A home health agency ~~with offices in two states~~ discovers on June 10 that a stolen, unencrypted laptop held records for 700 residents of one state. ~~The laptop was a 2021 model.~~ Which notification duties apply?

Target word: notice duties **Decides:** 500 or more residents of one state affected.

A	Dropped element	Drops notice to the affected individuals.
B	Correct	500-plus in a state triggers media and contemporaneous HHS notice.
C	Confusion set	Year-end logging is the rule for breaches under 500.
D	Camouflage	Device age does not matter; unencrypted PHI does.

7. Answer D Concept 4 · transfer

A breach affected 120 individuals. When must the covered entity report it to HHS?

Target word: HHS timing under 500 **Decides:** Fewer than 500 affected.

A	Confusion set	That is the 500-plus rule.
B	Absolute language	They are reported, just annually.
C	Adjacent category	Reporting does not depend on complaints.
D	Correct	Small breaches are logged and reported annually.

8. Answer B Concept 5

A federally assisted substance use disorder treatment program ~~in a city with a new light rail line~~ receives a request from a patient's employer for treatment records. The patient has not consented. ~~The program director has 20 years of experience.~~ What should the program do?

Target word: response **Decides:** Part 2 records without consent.

A	Camouflage	Experience does not replace consent.
B	Correct	42 CFR Part 2 generally requires written consent.
C	Dropped element	Even confirming treatment reveals protected information.
D	Adjacent category	Employers have no general right to treatment records.

9. Answer A Concept 6

An HIM department ~~with a new scanning system~~ receives a subpoena for a patient's records in a civil lawsuit, signed only by an attorney. There is no court order, no patient authorization, and no assurance that the patient was notified. What should HIM do?

Target word: response **Decides:** Attorney-signed subpoena with none of the required assurances.

A	Correct	Without these, HIPAA does not permit release on an attorney subpoena alone.
B	Camouflage	Ease of copying does not decide legal permission.
C	Absolute language	An attorney-signed subpoena needs more under HIPAA.
D	Dropped element	Drops the duty to respond properly.

10. Answer B Concept 6 · transfer

HIM receives an order for records signed by a judge. How does this differ from an attorney-signed subpoena?

Target word: reverse: judge-signed **Decides:** Court orders carry the court's authority.

A	Inverted operation	Court orders do not need authorization.
B	Correct	HIPAA permits disclosure as expressly authorized by a court order.
C	Confusion set	The judge's signature changes the requirements.
D	Absolute language	Release is limited to what the order specifies.

11. Answer C Concept 7

A patient at an orthopedic clinic ~~with Saturday hours~~ notices that her chart lists the wrong allergy, and the physician agrees it is an error. ~~The patient is a retired teacher.~~ How should the record be corrected?

Target word: correction method **Decides:** Legal record integrity.

A	Absolute language	Records can be amended through proper steps.
B	Inverted operation	Deleting destroys the legal record.
C	Correct	Preserves the audit trail and shows the correction.
D	Dropped element	Drops the audit trail.

12. Answer C Concept 8

An HIM coder at a pediatric hospital ~~known for its research program~~ finds documentation strongly suggesting child abuse that no one appears to have reported. The coder's supervisor says it is not the coder's job. What action is most consistent with legal and ethical duties?

Target word: best action **Decides:** Suspected abuse must be reported, and HIPAA permits it.

A	Adjacent category	Outside the coder's role and could put the child at risk.
B	Confusion set	Treats a supervisor's view as settling a legal and ethical duty.
C	Correct	HIPAA permits legally required abuse reports; escalation reaches the right reporter.
D	Absolute language	Required-by-law disclosures are permitted.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	6	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	5	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	3	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	9	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	5	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Treatment, payment, and operations (TPO)	HIPAA lets covered entities use and disclose PHI for treatment, payment, and health care operations without the patient's written authorization.	Requiring authorization for every disclosure.	One provider sends records to another provider caring for the patient.
2	Minimum necessary	Uses and disclosures for payment and operations are limited to the minimum necessary; the standard does not apply to disclosures to a provider for treatment.	Sending the whole record because the purpose is permitted.	A request for "the entire record" for a narrow purpose.
3	Right of access timing	A covered entity must act on an access request within 30 days, with one 30-day extension if the patient is told in writing.	Using the 60-day breach deadline or letting a vendor backlog decide.	A patient asks for a copy of her own records.
4	Breach notification	Notify individuals within 60 days of discovery; 500 or more residents of a state also triggers media notice and HHS notice within 60 days; fewer than 500 are logged and reported to HHS within 60 days after the calendar year ends.	Mixing the under-500 and 500-plus rules.	A count of affected people and a discovery date.
5	42 CFR Part 2	Federally assisted substance use disorder program records have stricter protection and generally need the patient's written consent before disclosure.	Treating SUD records like ordinary PHI.	A request to a substance use disorder treatment program.
6	Subpoenas vs. court orders	A court order signed by a judge may be followed for what it names; an attorney-signed subpoena alone needs satisfactory assurances, patient authorization, or a court order.	Treating every subpoena as a command to release everything.	Who signed the document.
7	Amending the record	Errors are corrected by a dated, signed amendment that keeps the original entry visible; nothing is deleted or overwritten.	Deleting or overwriting the wrong entry.	A provider agrees an entry is wrong.
8	Mandatory reporting and ethics	HIPAA permits disclosures required by law, such as suspected child abuse reports; staff should escalate through designated channels.	Believing HIPAA bars all reporting without authorization.	Signs of abuse no one has reported.

Course scope (public description): Health Information Law and Regulations prepares students to manage health information in compliance with legal guidelines and teaches how to respond to questions and challenges

when legal issues occur. This course presents the types of situations occurring in health information management that could result in ethical dilemmas and establishes a foundation for work based on legal and ethical guidelines.